



University of Wisconsin
**SCHOOL OF MEDICINE
AND PUBLIC HEALTH**

Covariate-Adjusted Topological Inference and Learning

Moo K. Chung
University of Wisconsin-
Madison

mkchung@wisc.edu

Abstract: Many structured datasets—from neuroimaging to genomics—are influenced by nuisance covariates such as age, sex, or acquisition site. Traditional machine learning techniques for embedding and clustering often overlook these effects, leading to confounded comparisons where true biological differences are obscured by covariate-driven variation. We address this limitation by formulating covariate adjustment, including data harmonization, as defining equivalence classes in the sense of group theory: two data objects are equivalent if they differ only by the action of a covariate operator representing variation explained by covariates. The resulting latent quotient space provides a statistically principled framework for non-Euclidean and structured data, partitioning observations into equivalence classes that capture intrinsic structure after removing nuisance effects.

We demonstrate this framework in topological data analysis (TDA), where persistent topological features are embedded in a Hilbert space and adjusted via orthogonal projection, thereby constructing the quotient space. This enables downstream tasks such as embedding and clustering to be performed free from confounding influences. As a primary application, we analyze human brain networks from resting-state fMRI, adjusting for covariates such as sex, age, and acquisition site. Covariate-adjusted TDA markedly reduces variability and improves interpretability, offering a powerful, generalizable approach for reproducible and robust neuroscience.

Talk is based partially based on

Vector Space of Cycles

Moo K. Chung¹

Anass B. El-Yaagoubi²

Hernando Ombao²

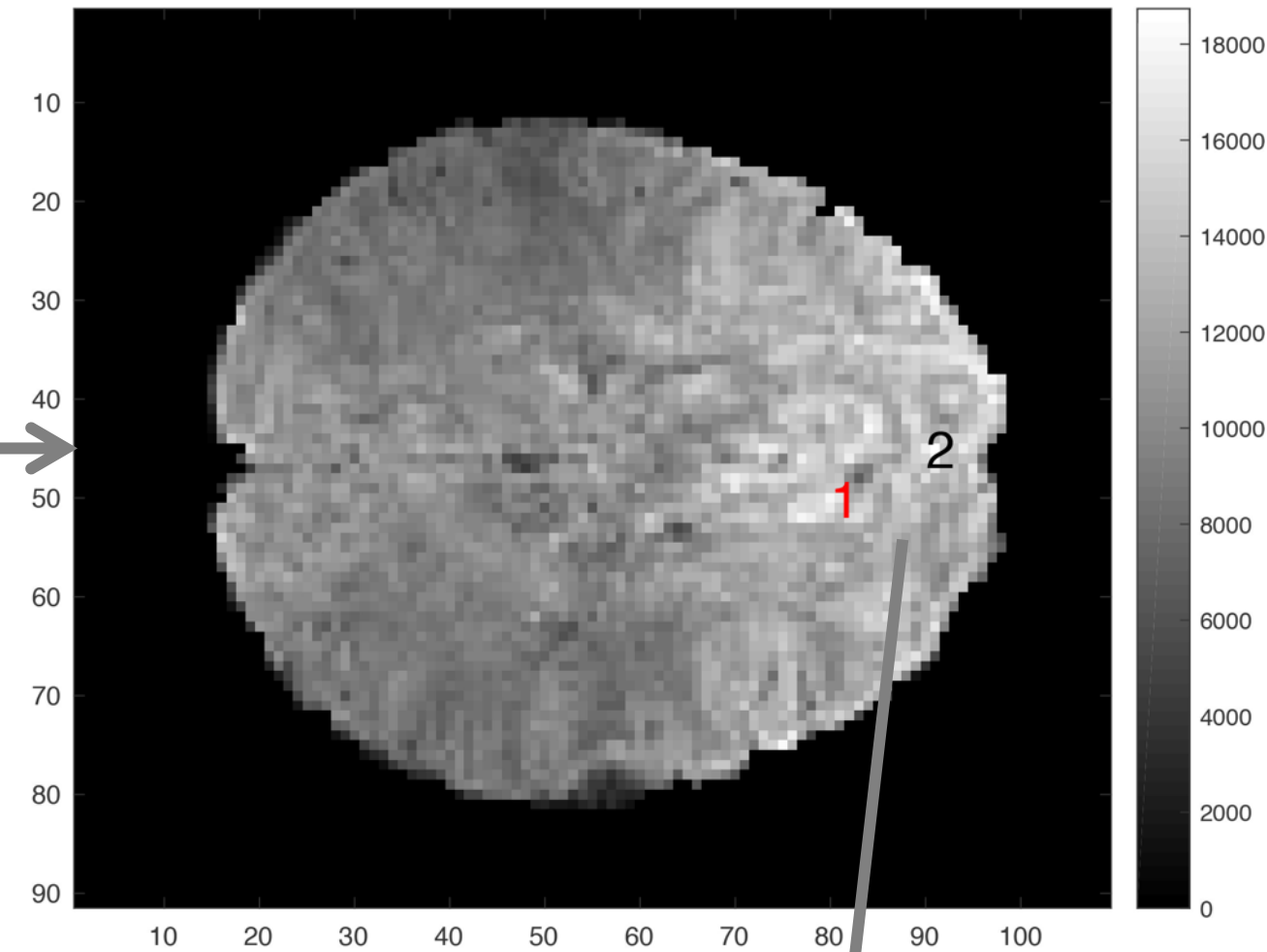
¹Department of Biostatistics and Medical Informatics, University of Wisconsin, Madison, Wisconsin, USA

²Statistics Program, King Abdullah University of Science and Technology, Thuwal, Saudi Arabia

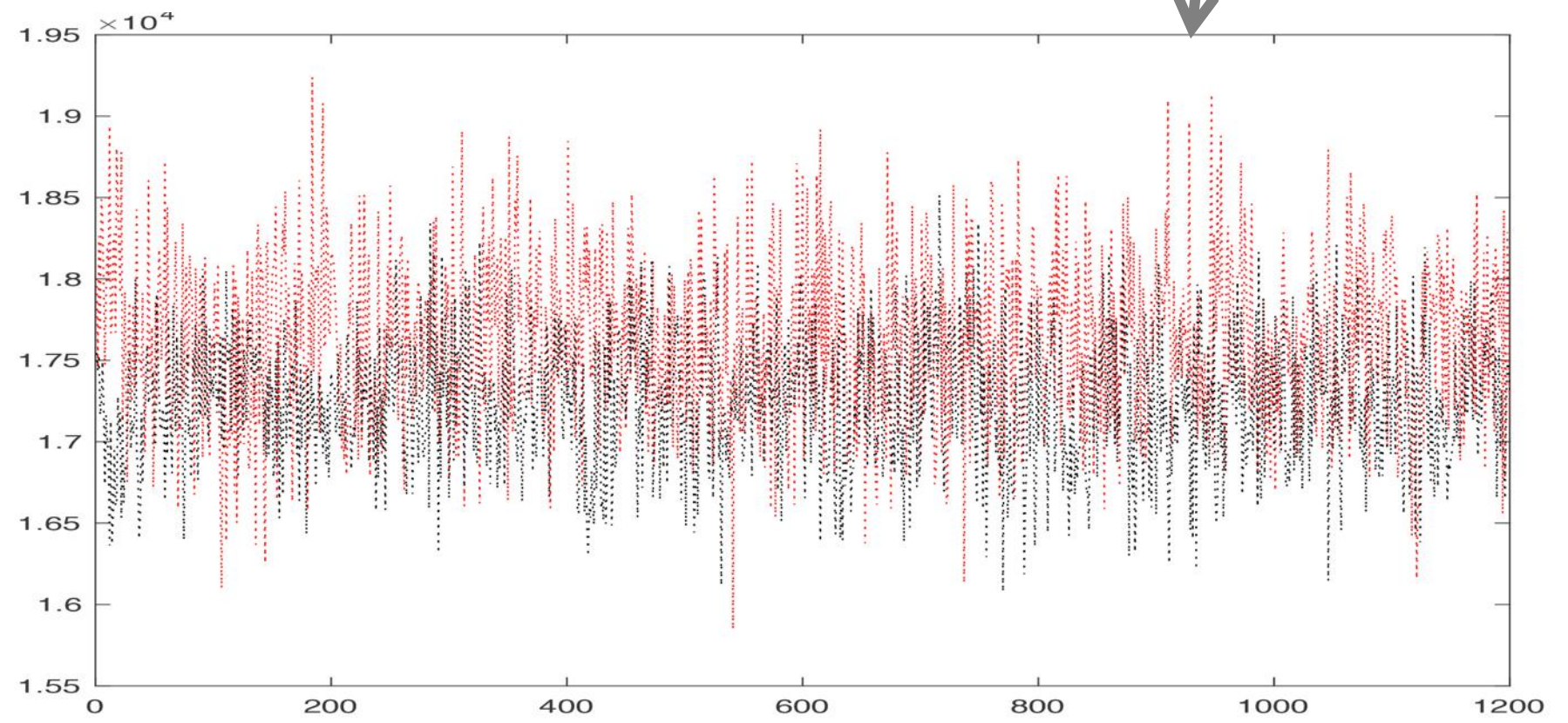
[arXiv:2606.08202](https://arxiv.org/abs/2606.08202)

Grants: NIH MH133614, NSF DMS-2010778

Resting-state functional magnetic resonance imaging (rs-fMRI)

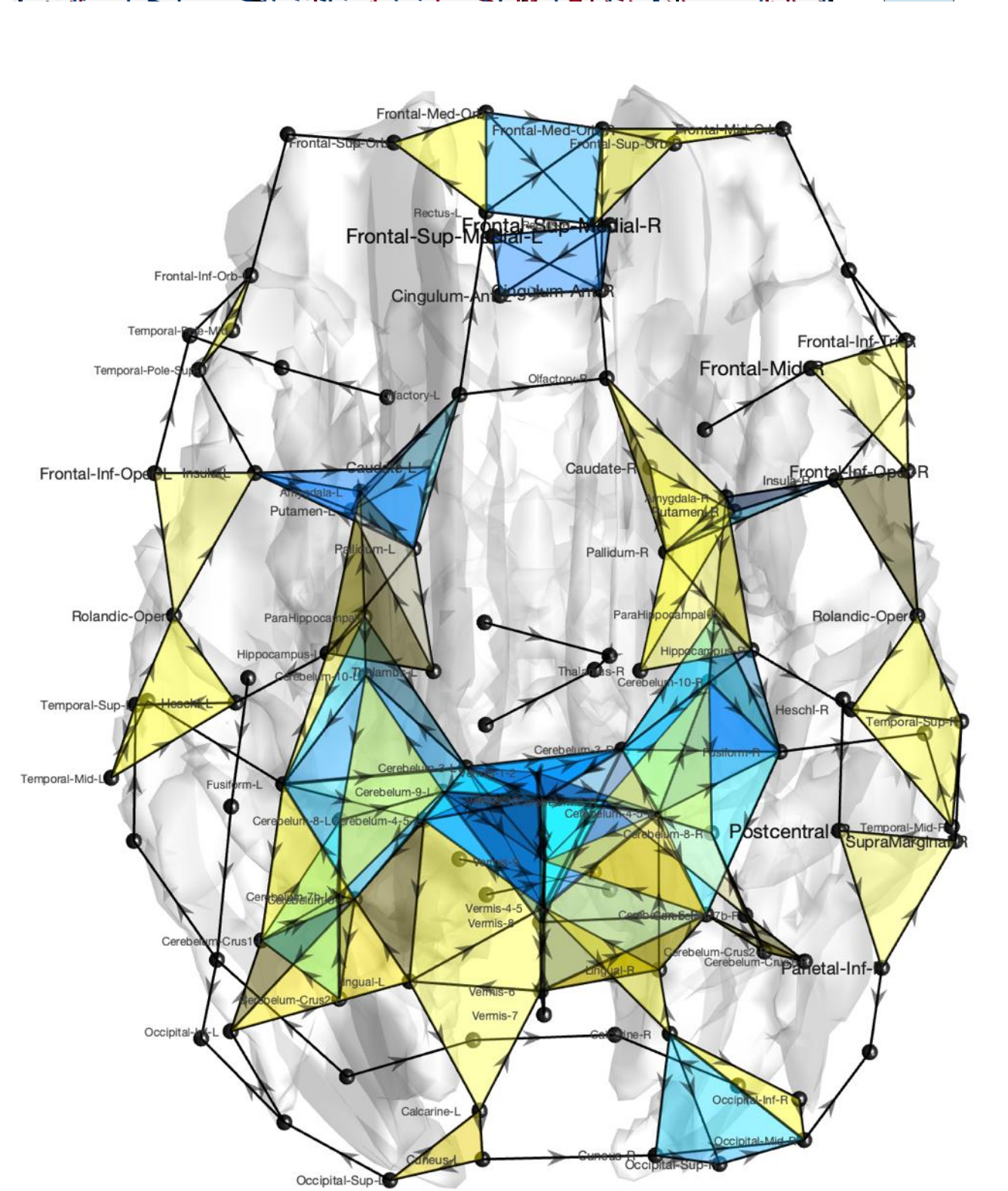


Neuronal activity over 14min.



Simplicial complex data structure

Simplicial complex data structure



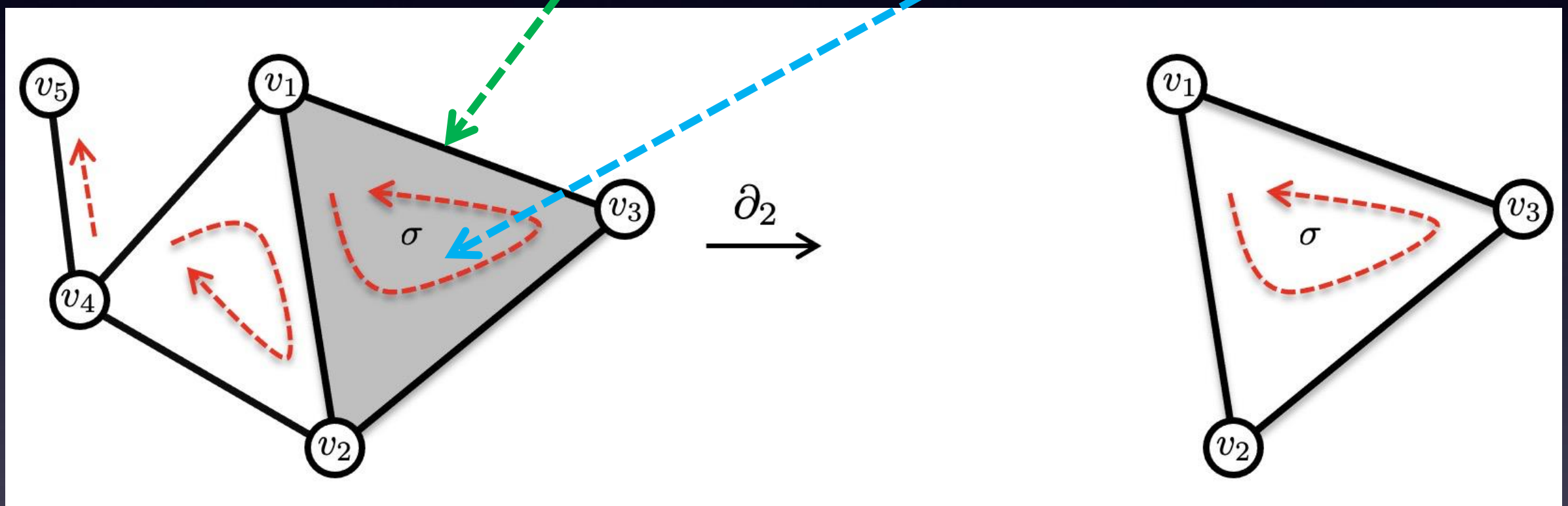
Anand & Chung, 2023 IEEE TMI

1st Hodge Laplacian

*Anand and Chung, 2023, IEEE
TMI*

Anand and Chung, 2024 ISBI

$$\Delta_1 = \overset{\substack{\text{\# of nodes} \\ \text{\# of edges}}}{\mathbf{B}_1^T \mathbf{B}_1} + \overset{\substack{\text{\# of edges} \\ \text{\# of faces}}}{\mathbf{B}_2 \mathbf{B}_2^T}$$



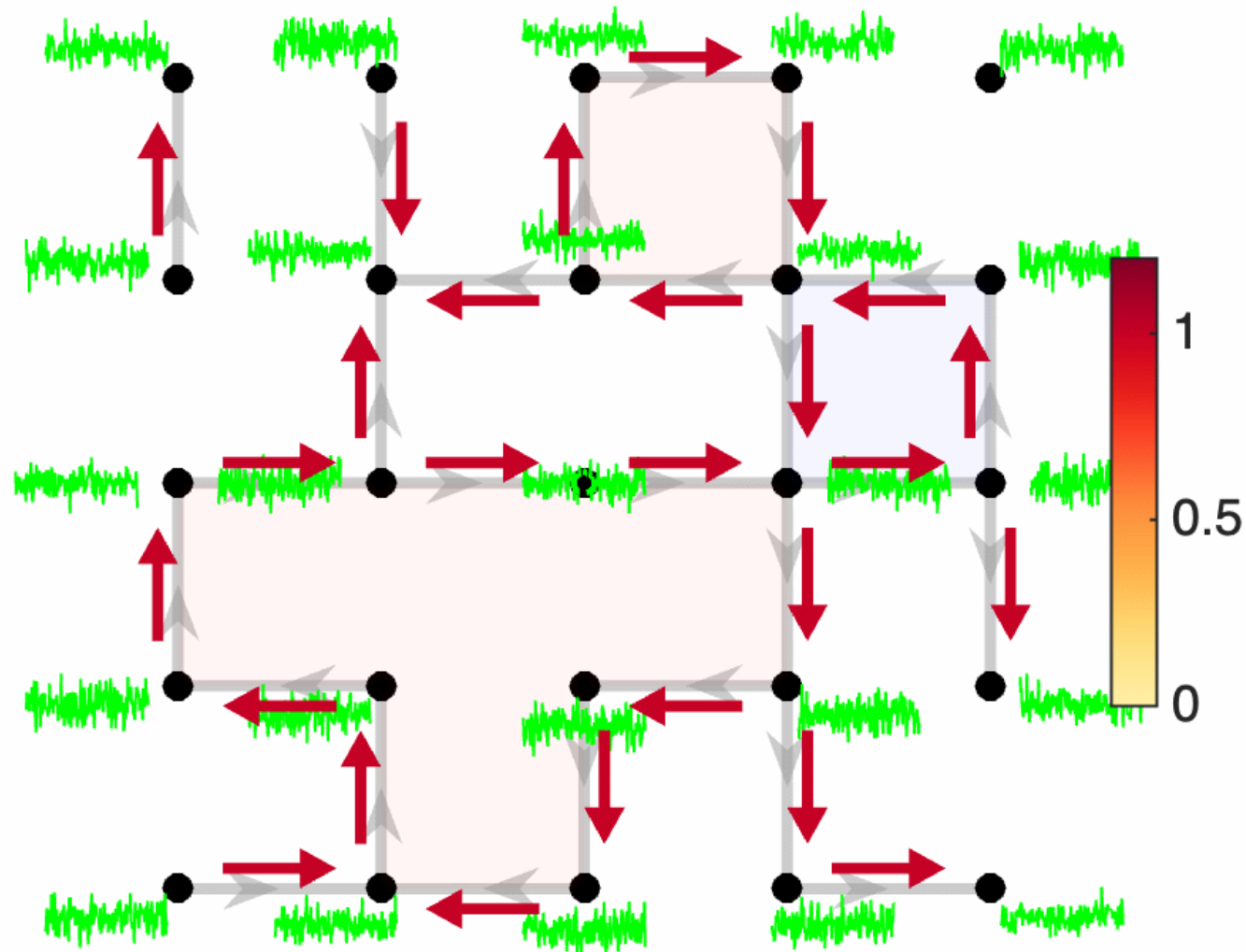
0th Hodge Laplacian
Graph Laplacian

$$\Delta_0 = \overset{\substack{\text{\# of edges} \\ \text{\# of nodes}}}{\mathbf{B}_1^T \mathbf{B}_1}$$

Dirichlet-Hodge diffusion Dynamics

Diffusion on edge flow

Damped Euler-Lagrangian (t = 0.00)



Chung et al. 2026 ISBI

$$\dot{X}(t) = -\Delta_1 X(t)$$

$$X(t) = e^{-\Delta_1 t} X(0)$$

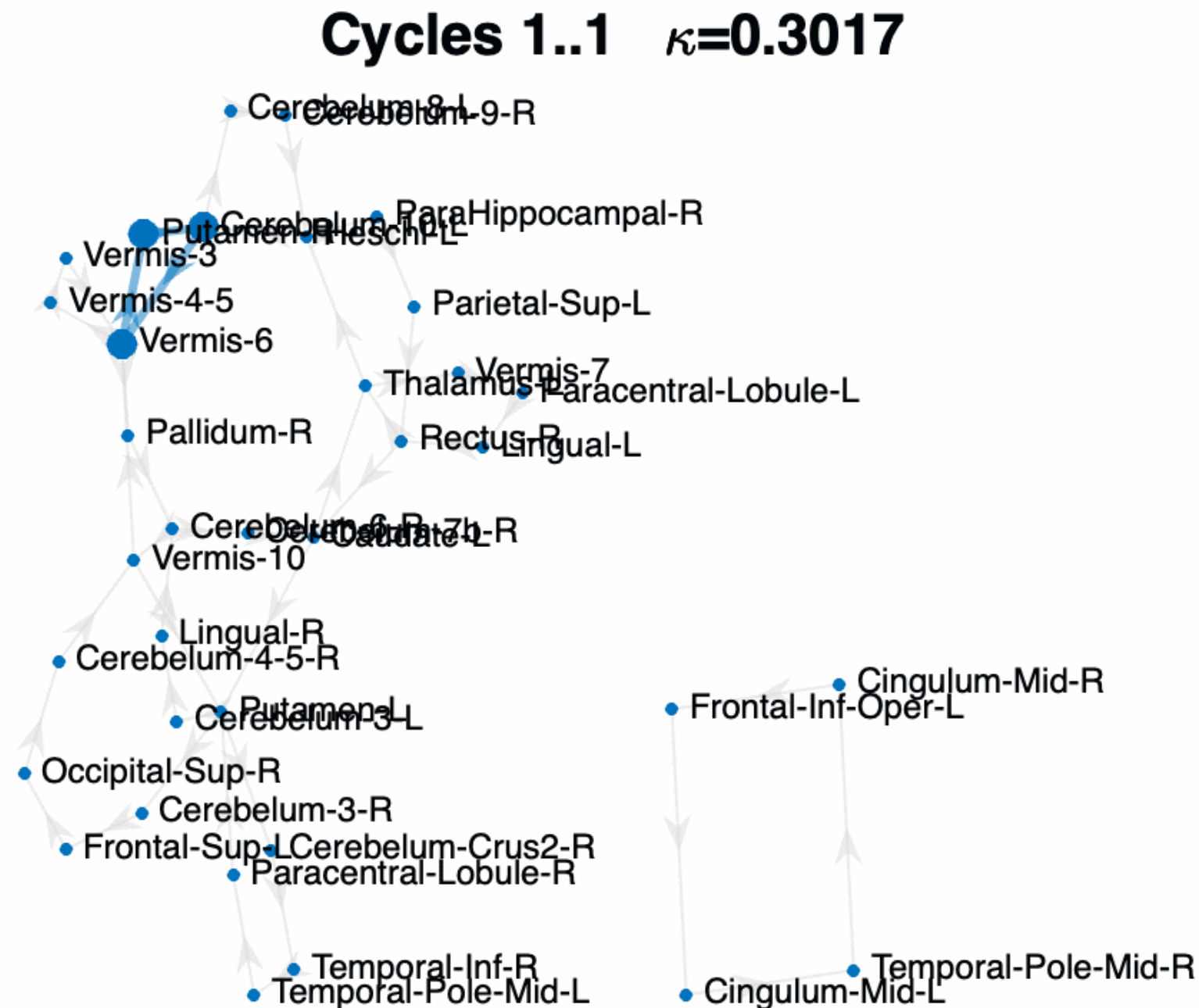
$$\sum_K e^{-\lambda_k t} \psi_k \psi_k^\top$$

Cyclic interactions

$$X_H = \mathcal{P}_H X(0)$$

$$\sum_k \psi_k \psi_k^\top$$

Average cyclic interactions of 400 subjects over 14min

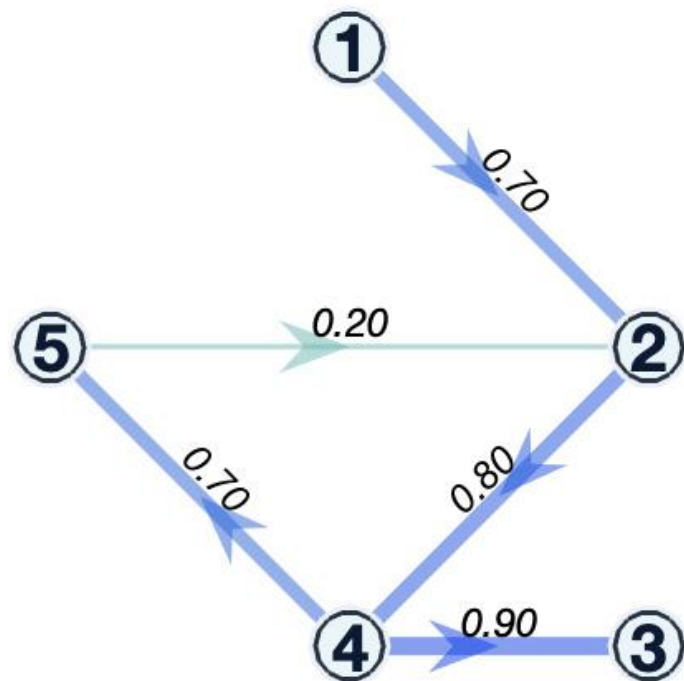


How to covariate adjust cyclic interactions under the influence of sex, site, ages etc.

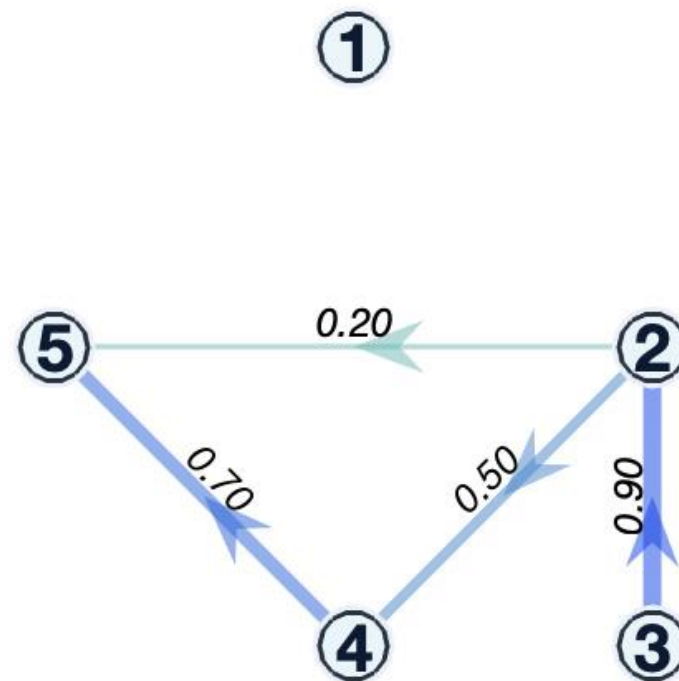
Covariating edges will destroy cycles.

$\ker(\Delta_1) \neq$ Vector space of cycles

Network 1



Network 2

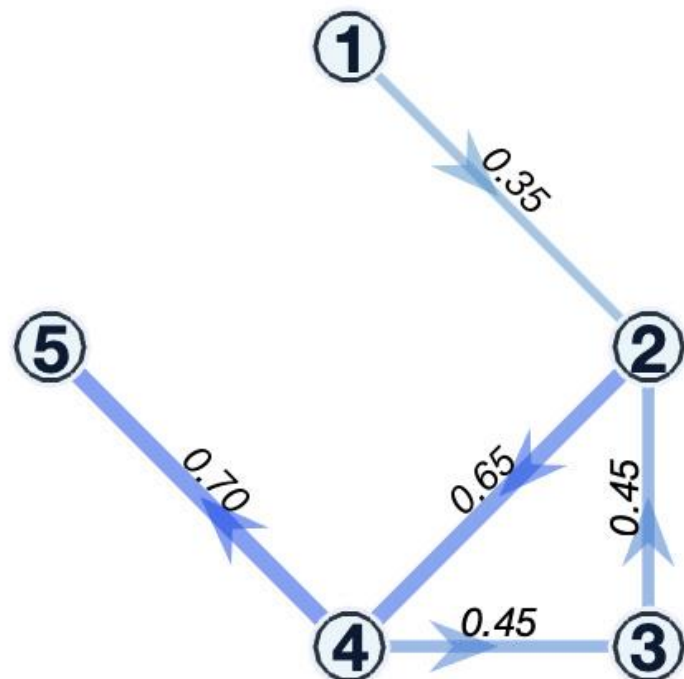


Cycles

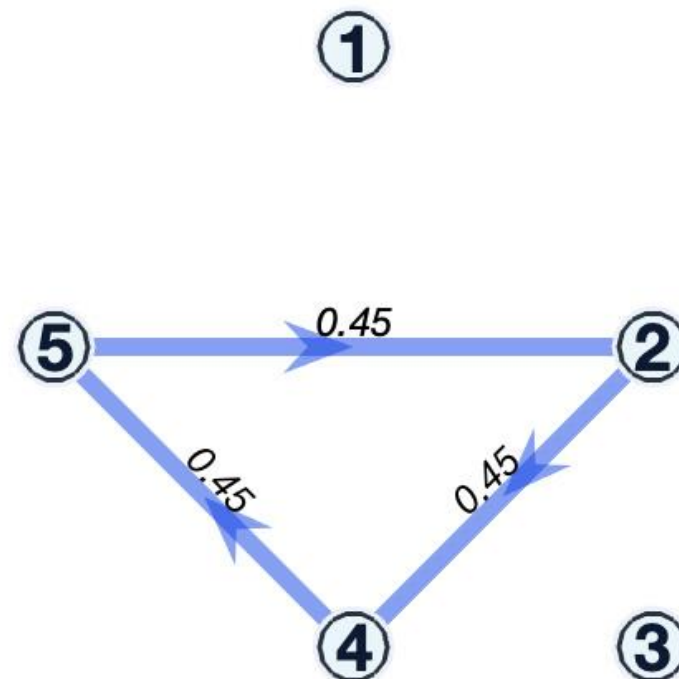
$$C_1, C_2 \in \ker(\Delta_1)$$

$$\alpha_1 C_1 + \alpha_2 C_2 \in \ker(\Delta_1)$$

Algebraic Averaging



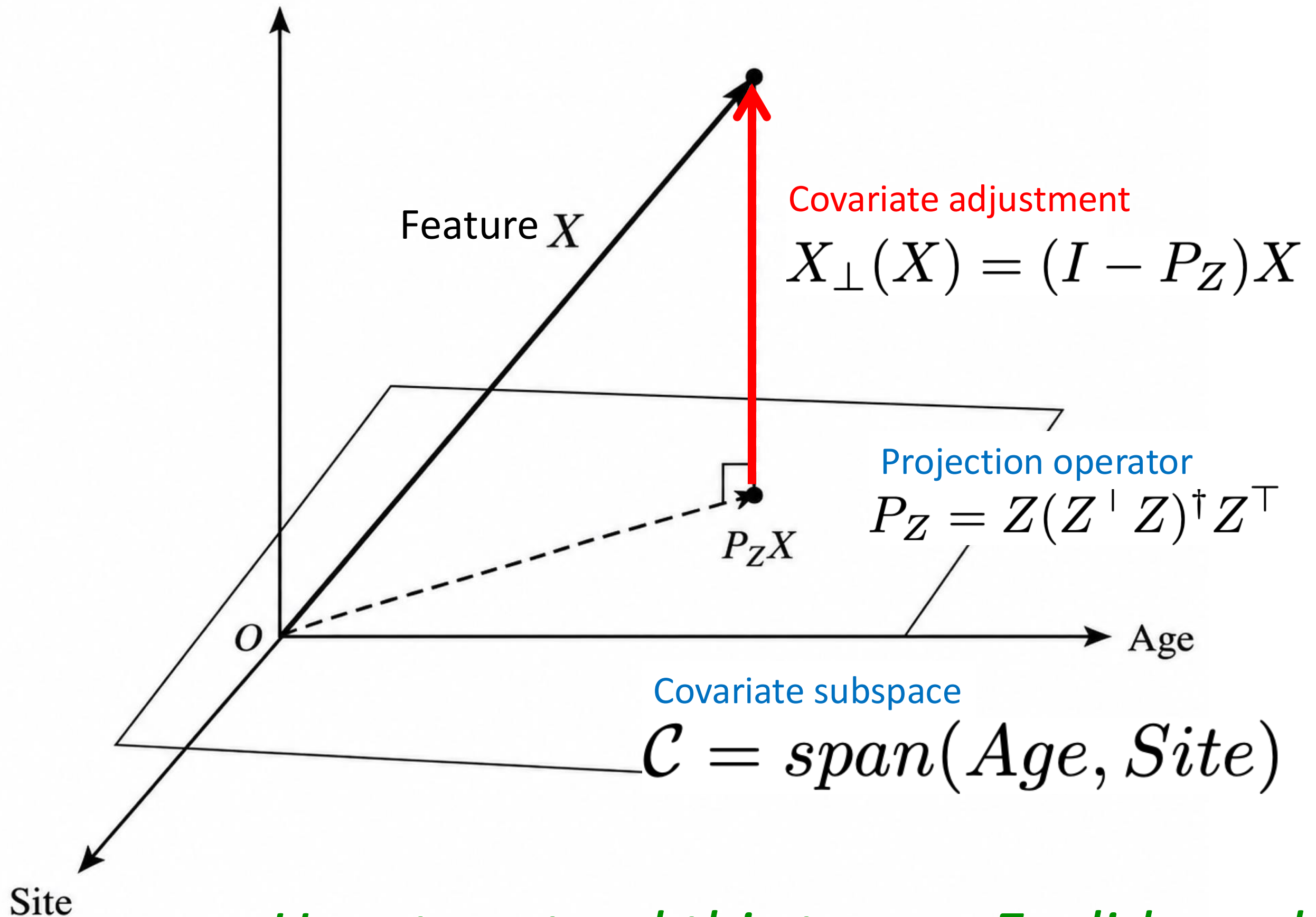
Averaging in Cycle Space



Anand and
Chung, 2023,
IEEE TMI

*Need to develop a
more general method*

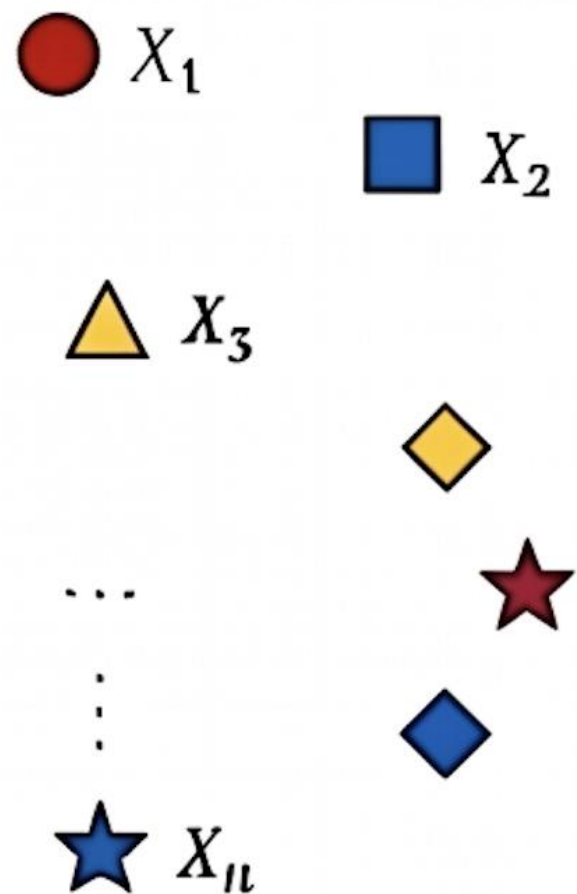
Covariate adjustment as a projection operator



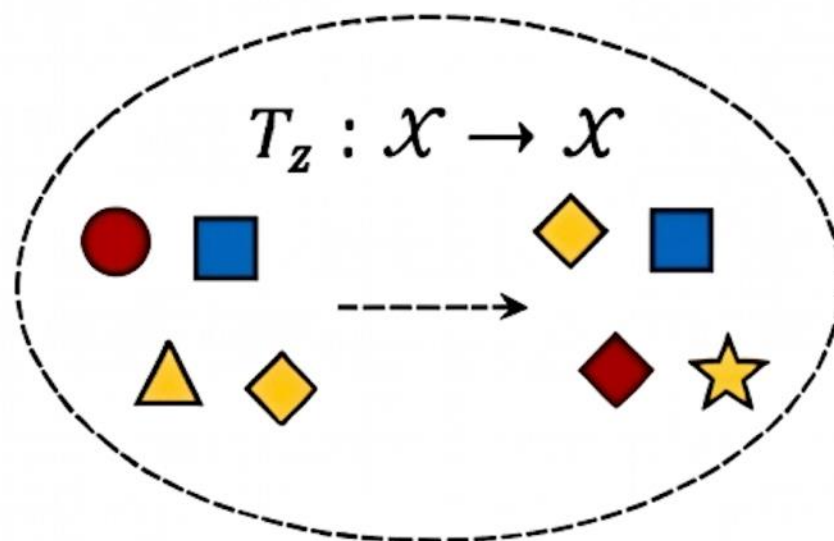
How to extend this to non-Euclidean data

Covariate adjustment via group action

Data Space $\mathcal{X}$



Affect of covariates

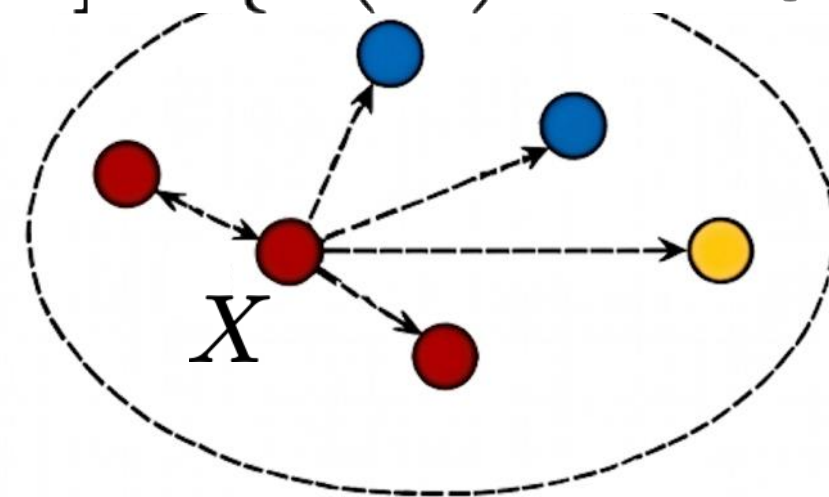


Group

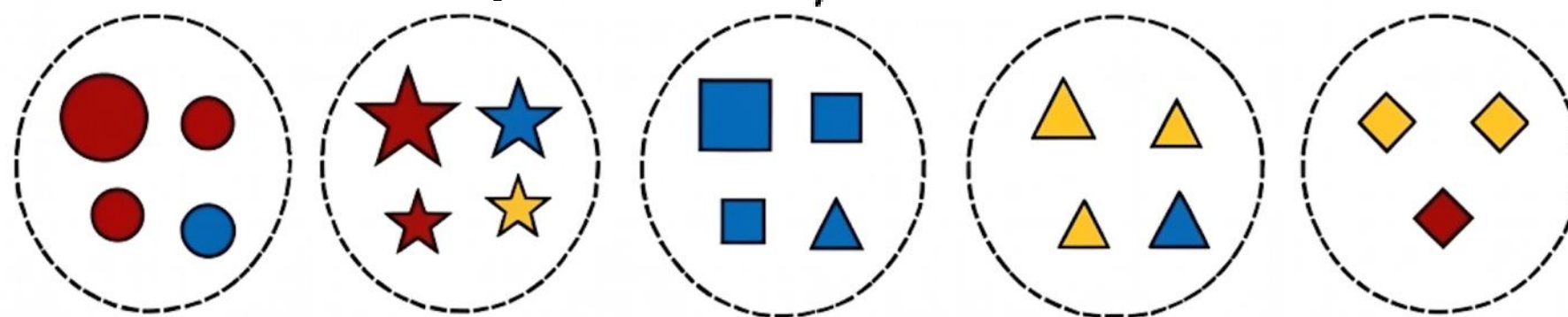
$$\mathcal{G} = \{T_z : z \in \text{span}(Z)\}$$

Equivalence class

$$[X] = \{T(X) : T \in \mathcal{G}\}$$

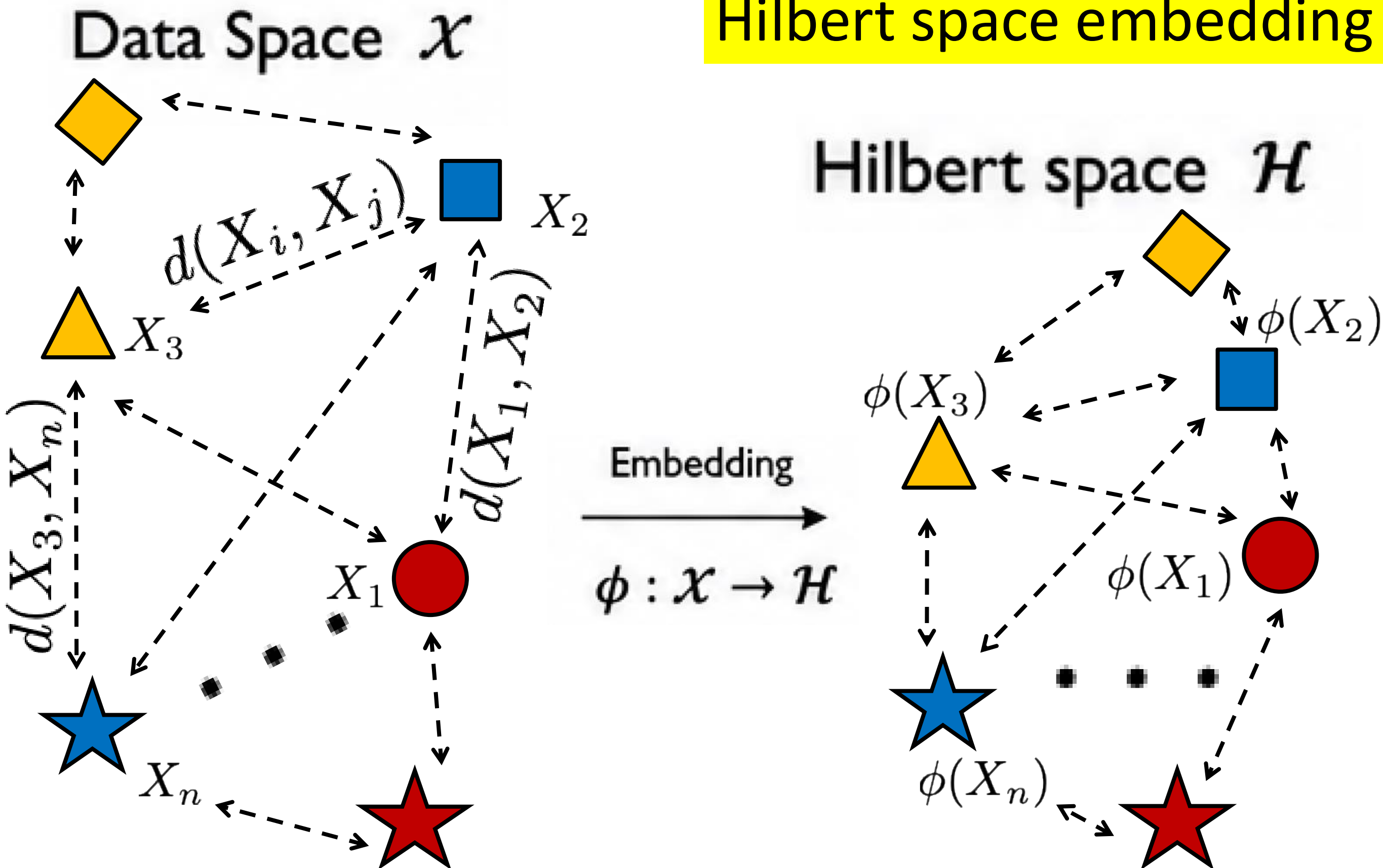


Quotient space $\mathcal{X}/\mathcal{G}$



How to compute these in

Hilbert space embedding



$$d(X_i, X_j) = \|\phi(X_i) - \phi(X_j)\|$$

Covariate adjustment in embedding space

$$\phi_{\perp}(X) = (I - P_{\mathcal{C}})\phi(X)$$

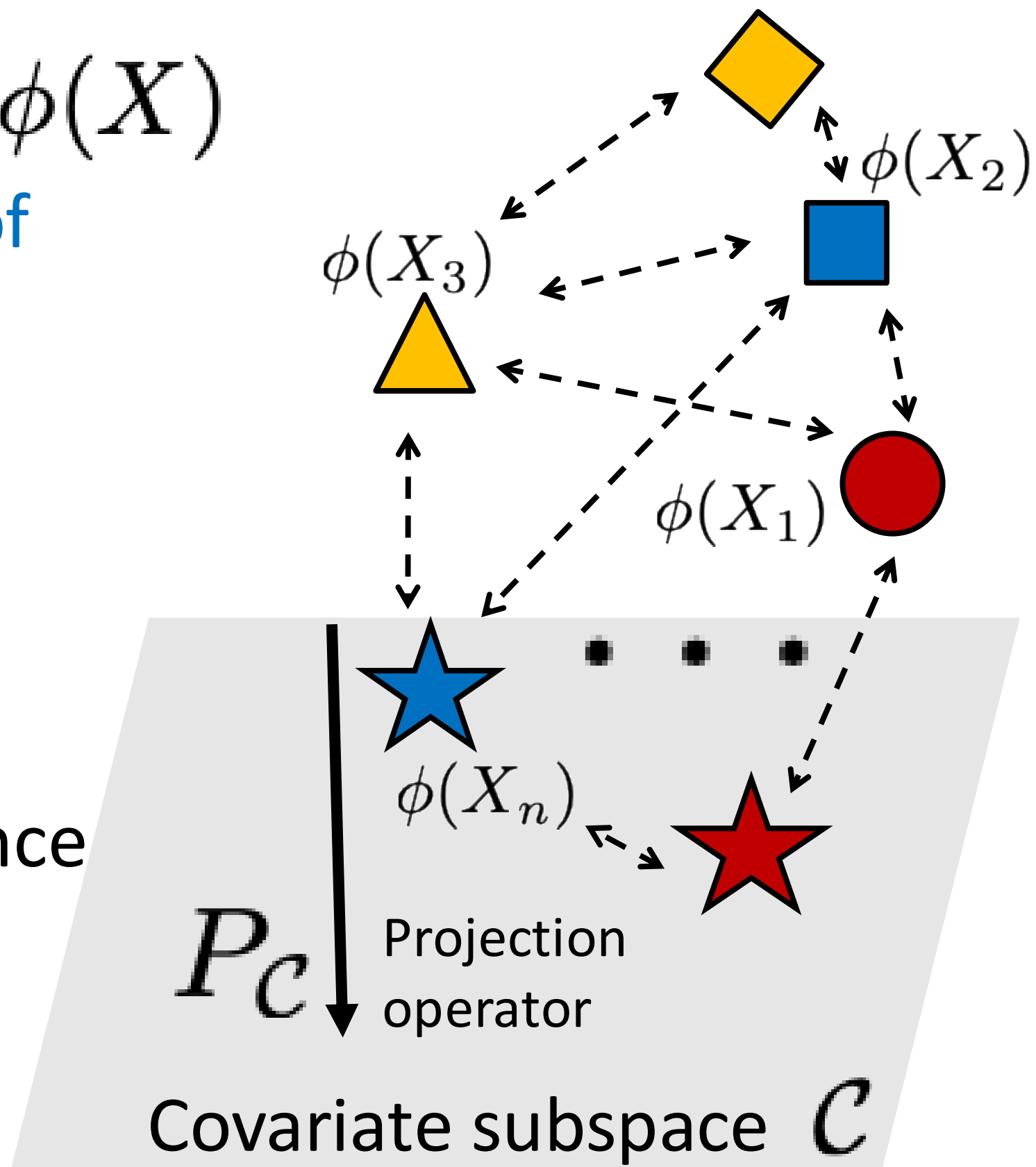
Intrinsic representation of
object after removing
variation attributable to
nuisance covariates

Covariate adjusted distance

$$d_{\perp}(X_i, X_j)$$

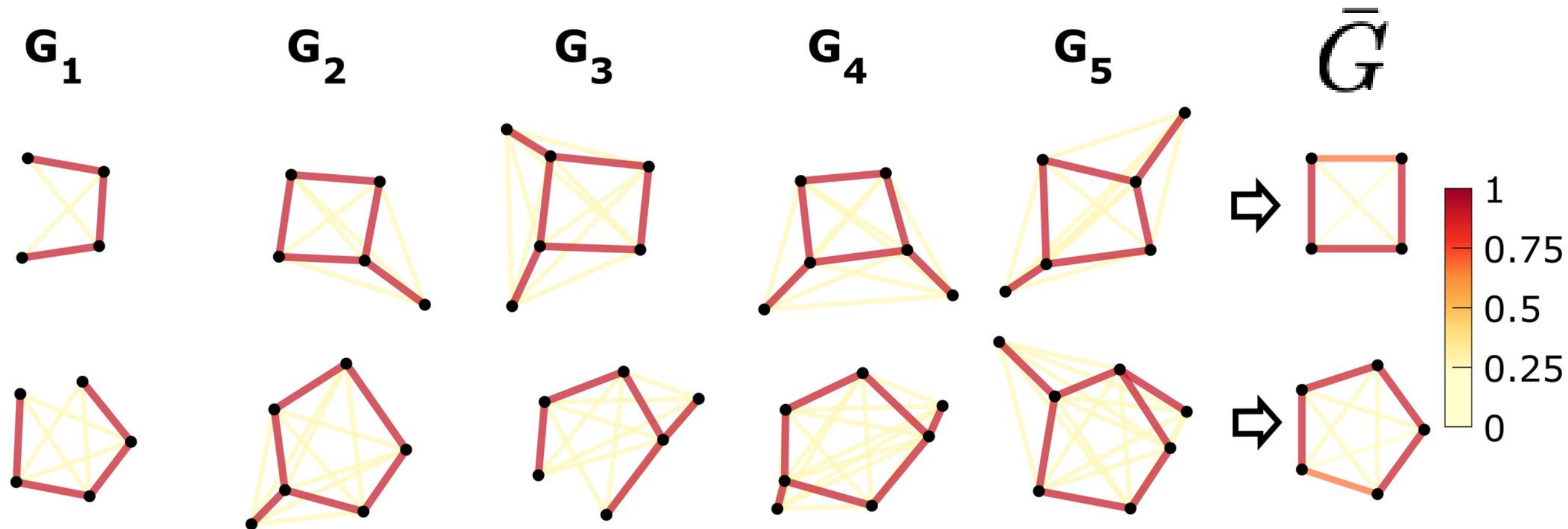
$$= \|\phi_{\perp}(X_i) - \phi_{\perp}(X_j)\|$$

Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$



Application to topological distance

Wasserstein distance on persistent homology features



$$\bar{G} = \arg \min_{\Theta} \sum_{k=1}^n d(\Theta, G_i)$$

Analytic solution

Songdechakraiwut & Chung, 2023 *Annals of Applied*

Covariate adjusted topological clustering

ages

30

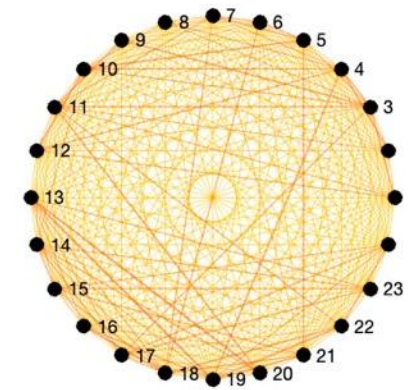
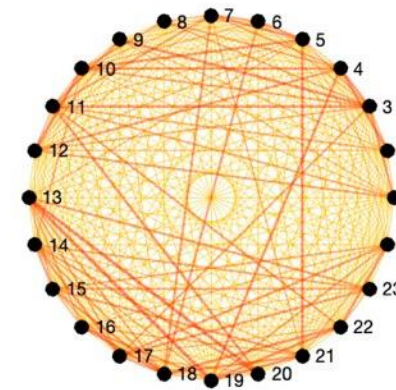
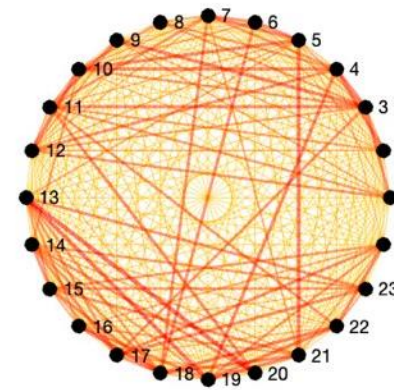
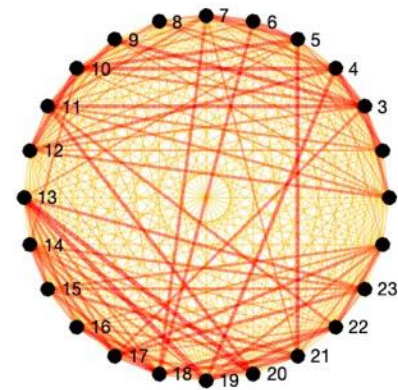
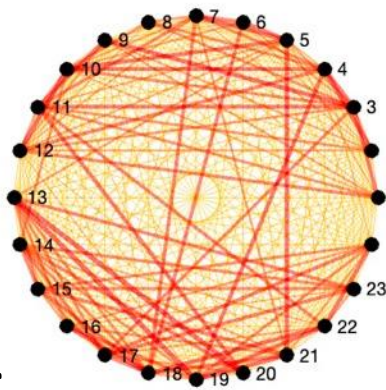
40

50

60

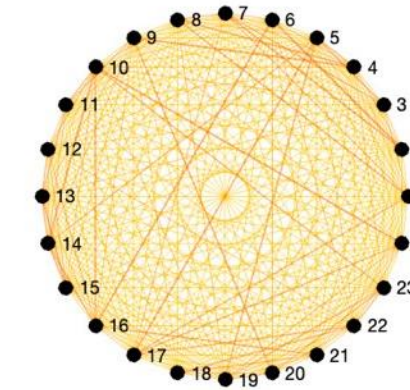
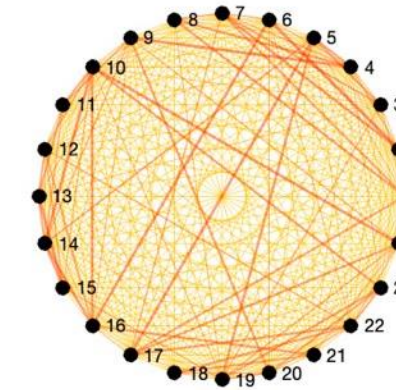
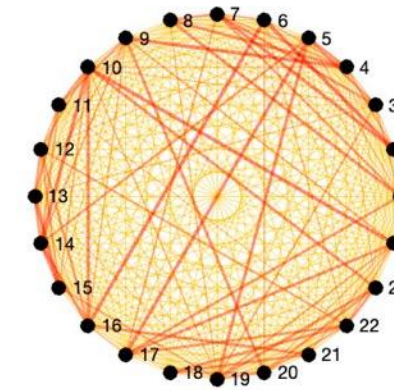
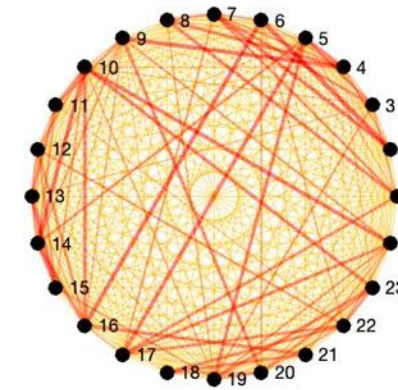
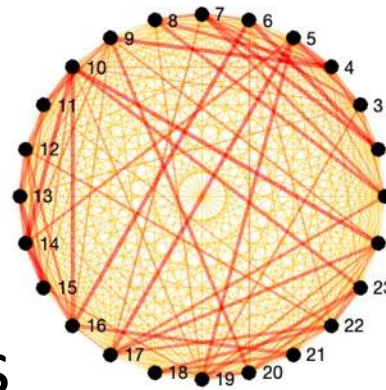
70

2-modules



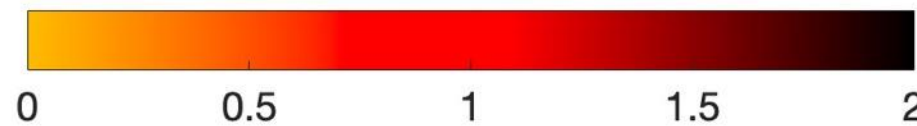
Group 1

3-modules



Group 2

Connectivity



Accuracy

0.60+-0.02

After adjustment

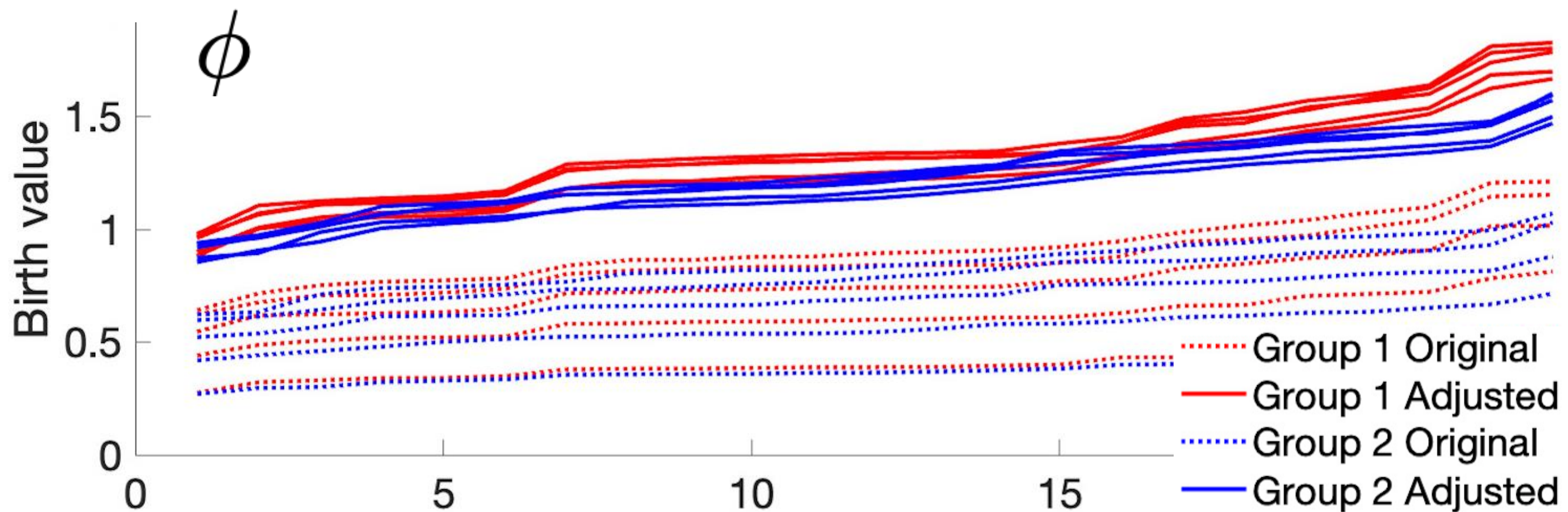
-----> 0.67+-0.05

Decomposition of Wassertein distance

$$d(X_i, X_j) = \|\phi(X_i) - \phi(X_j)\|$$

Wasserstein distance
on persistent homology
features

Monotone function



Need to solve projection with monotonicity

Thank you.

We are here.

